

tripartite talks that include Pakistan.

Informed sources say that well before Chidambaram announced the offer, Delhi apparently ensured certain "commitments" from some separatist leaders. Senior leader Shabir Ahmed Shah said that chief of the Intelligence Bureau had visited him during his detention in a Jammu jail, but he rejected the offer of dialogue and reiterated his stand of sticking to tripartite talks or implementing the UN resolution for resolving the issue.

Despite these hiccups, Delhi has started deploying its old horses in Kashmir to smoothen the ground. Wajahat Habibullah gave up his job as the country's chief information com-

Meanwhile, the unionist parties who support Centre's initiative have redoubled their efforts at infiltrating separatist political territory. Opposition People's Democratic Party (PDP) is busy mobilising public opinion about its purported "self-rule formula" as an alternative to azadi achievable within the Indian Constitution. A worried NC used Manmohan's visit to claim the territory it feels the PDP is fast overtaking. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah let Manmohan know during the inauguration of the rail link that more than the economics, it was the political aspect that should form the core of fresh talks. "The basic issue of Kashmir is not about money (development), it is



Packaged Hope

Several previous initiatives still remain mostly on paper

- 1996** Economic package, including Rs 2,600 crore for Udhampur-Baramulla Rail Link, announced
- 2002** Kashmir gets a Rs 6,165 -crore package
- 2003** Another Rs 3,000-crore package announced
- 2004** Centre approves a reconstruction plan involving an outlay of Rs 24,000 crore
- 2008** Rs 1,600-crore financial assistance to help Kashmiri Pandits return home announced

missioner to take up a similar job at the state level. Political pundits in the Valley bet it's a political move given his vast experience of dealing with separatists during the tumultuous early 1990s as the divisional commissioner. Officialdom in Srinagar is equally unhopeful. "Manmohan's visit should have been around policy approaches. Instead, he talked about procedures. Attempts at political co-option will not work anymore as a way ahead," a senior security official said.

political in nature. The youth of Kashmir didn't pick up guns for money, but for political reasons and it is from politics that a lasting solution should be found," he said.

The prime minister has expressed hope that the spirit in which he offered the dialogue would be reciprocated in the same spirit. But all it seems to be doing is that both separatists and unionists are using the expected dialogue to further consolidate their constituencies on the ground. ■

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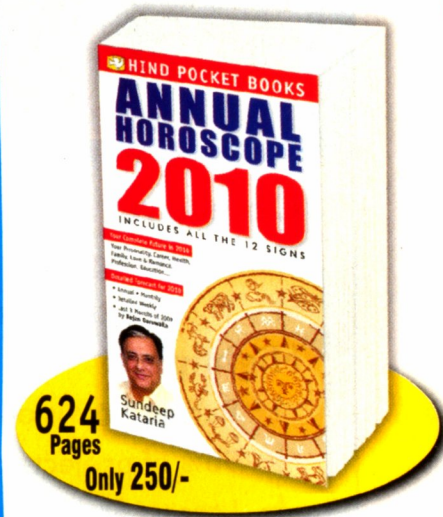
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